So, delighting in his drum and basking in the affection of his great-aunt, Akbar survived the winter darkness in Kabul; and, in the spring of 1545, news arrived that his father had besieged Qandahar.

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The struggle for Qandahar was as much diplomatic as it was military. Urgent embassies travelled between Humayun at the gates of the fort, Askari within, and Kamran on edge in Kabul. Bairam Khan was among these confidential envoys, and thus met young Akbar in a Kabul garden, neither of them knowing they would change the history of the world between them. When Bairam Khan arrived, Akbar was playing with Khanzada, who, too, was an ambassador between the warring brothers; it was she, in fact, who went to Qandahar and negotiated the terms of Askari's eventual surrender so that, on 3 September 1545, six months after the siege began, Askari came out of the fort in all humility, his sword hung around his neck and Khanzada by his side, to be forgiven by his for-once victorious brother, Humayun.

Khanzada may have negotiated a relatively peaceful agreement between Askari and Humayun in Qandahar, but she'd had to leave Akbar behind to do so. Now, in Kabul, Kamran heard the news of Askari's defeat and took Akbar out of Khanzada's quarters and gave him to his own wife, Khanim Begum. Then, as if to make his mala fides crystal clear, he put Akbar's most loyal male guardian, Shamsuddin Muhammad, in prison. Clearly, Kamran was rattled, and with reason. He might have secured a valuable hostage, but news of Humayun's victory had loosened Kamran's grip on the men and women he had gathered around himself during Humayun's exile.

Among them was the youngest of the four brothers, Hindal. Having marched off in anger when Humayun married Hamida, Hindal had arrived in Qandahar, made some unsuccessful attempts to take it for himself, then become a virtual prisoner of Kamran's. Yadgar Nasir, their cousin, had remained in Sindh to try his luck; when he failed, he too had no refuge but Kabul and Kamran. Sulaiman, their cousin and ruler of Badakhshan, along with his wife Haram Begum and their son Ibrahim, were also amongst Kamran's unwilling guests – all of whom now took the opportunity to take their leave.

Not that Humayun was in any position to march upon Kabul. The victory